Research Essay:
Grocery Store Observation

Albert Yang | *Partners: Kevin Gao, Ji Tae Kim*

When I visited the Giant Eagle in Market District with Kevin and Ji Tae, what we saw was a big, bustling space with people on shopping carts making it feel overall pretty cramped. Most of the people were shopping alone and seemed very goal-oriented. Groceries and products covered every aisle, where most people were pushing their cart forward while glancing each shelf in search of what they needed. Many shoppers who were looking carefully at the aisles looked like they were in their 50s or older, potentially searching for a specific brand of product that's healthier than other options.

While many people were shopping alone, some went with a companion (a friend, child, or significant other) or even, albeit rarely, a family. When there were pairs or groups of people shopping together, social interaction between them was much more noticeable. In particular, we noticed a man and a woman arguing about which brand of peanut butter was healthier. In another part of the store, an Italian family was arguing in their native language at one end of an aisle. While we couldn't understand what they were talking about, it brings up the question of what makes people argue intensely about in a grocery store (besides peanut butter)?

The demographics of shoppers was very diverse, ranging from college students to senior citizens with a variety of ethnic backgrounds. What types of errands were these people running? I would guess that college students are mainly shopping for groceries to save money from eating out, and that the older demographic is shopping for healthier options for their cooking. We also noticed a middle-aged woman holding a notebad and reading it as she hovered around the milk section, so perhaps she had plans to bake something later that day. Many people were on their phones, so they could be asking someone what to buy. It's difficult to tell what people's motivations or plans were besides to look for food, but sometimes it could be inferred from where or what they were doing. For example, we noticed a woman standing with her shopping cart and reading what looked like a book of coupons. It's possible that she was searching for good deals that would otherwise expire soon, rather than actually needing those groceries.

The customers in the store almost never interacted with one another unless they were in the same party. Despite me and my partners occasionally blocking the aisleway, nobody told us to move and waited until we realized we were in the way. The parts of the store with the most interaction were in the butcher section and the check-out line. In the butcher section, shoppers waited with a ticket number in their hand as the clerks behind the counter called each one in succession to complete the customers' orders. The butcher and the shopper had a casual relationship, as shown by the former's joking nature while serving the latter. In the check-out line, the cashier also had a more robotic relationship with the shopper, and the interactions were much more subtle. In essence, some clerks seemed more intimate with the customer, while others were closed off and just did their job.